# Multiphoton interference and representation theory in the many-photon limit

PhD Candidacy Exam

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## Introduction

Multiphoton interference in linear optical networks is a fundamental quantum effect and an important resource for quantum technologies. Recent experiments have demonstrated programmable single-photon processors and shown how partial indistinguishability and collective photonic phases affect multiphoton probabilities [1, 2, 3]. Large-scale Gaussian boson sampling experiments and advances in classical simulation have also highlighted the challenges of demonstrating quantum computational advantage [4, 5]. Calculating multiphoton scattering amplitudes and probabilities becomes increasingly difficult as the number of photons increases, especially when partial indistinguishability is considered [6, 7]. This problem is closely related to boson sampling and computational complexity [8, 9, 10]. These difficulties motivate the search for a general description that can help us understand the behavior of multiphoton probabilities, even when their exact calculation is difficult.

Previous studies, including our own work, have established semiclassical correspondences between multiphoton interference and classical interferometry in the many-photon limit [11, 12]. These results provide one perspective on the problem, while representation theory provides another through the exact decomposition of the spatial state space into irreducible sectors of $U(M)$. In the reduced spatial description, partial indistinguishability allows contributions from sectors beyond the fully symmetric representation. Together, these results reveal connections between multiphoton interference, classical interferometry, and representation theory, while leaving open the question of how the contributions of the irreducible sectors are related to the classical description in the many-photon limit. These connections and the problems they raise form the starting point of this proposal.

This research focuses on the many-photon limit, $N \to \infty$, with a fixed number of modes $M$ and sequences of occupations whose fractions approach fixed values. Figure 1 illustrates the three domains involved: quantum multiphoton interference, the classical map from relative phases to output intensities, and the theory of irreducible representations of $U(M)$, whose sectors are labeled by Young diagrams that grow with $N$.

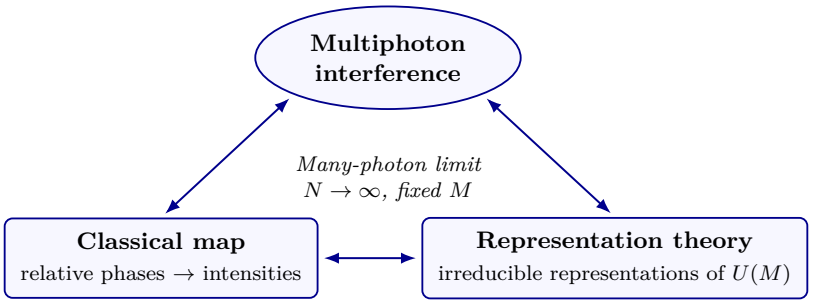



Figure 1: Correspondences between multiphoton interference, the classical map from relative phases to intensities, and the representation theory of $U(M)$ in the asymptotic multiphoton limit.

The first correspondence relates multiphoton probabilities to classical interferometry. In the many-photon limit, the macroscopic behavior of these probabilities is related to a classical measure induced by a map from relative phases to intensities [11, 12]. In our previous work, we expressed multiphoton states exactly through an expansion in tensor powers of auxiliary single-photon states, referred to as virtual states [12]. These states are parametrized by the relative input phases, and their propagation through the interferometer enables the definition of the classical map $C_{\rho,U}(\boldsymbol{\phi})$, which maps the torus of relative phases $\boldsymbol{\phi} \in \mathbb{T}^{M-1}$ to the simplex of normalized output intensities $\Delta_{M-1}$. The probabilities are exponentially suppressed at a positive distance from the image of the map, and, at regular points, their rescaled slowly varying component converges to the density of the induced classical measure. Under additional conditions on the interferometer and the rank of the effective matrix, this convergence also holds for the rescaled physical probabilities. When $M \geq 3$, the map may exhibit caustics and interior voids, the latter corresponding to regions without preimages. A general characterization of the interference contributions associated with different preimages, especially near caustics, remains

one of the problems motivating this research.

The second correspondence relates multiphoton interference to representation theory. Schur–Weyl duality provides an exact decomposition of the spatial state space into sectors $\mathcal{H}_\Lambda \otimes \mathcal{M}_\Lambda$, where $\mathcal{H}_\Lambda$ carries an irreducible representation of $U(M)$ labeled by a Young diagram and $\mathcal{M}_\Lambda$ is its Schur–Weyl multiplicity space [13, 14]. For perfectly indistinguishable photons, only the fully symmetric representation contributes, while partial indistinguishability allows contributions from other sectors. For two ports, the dominant contributions are concentrated in a window of $O(\sqrt{N})$ spin channels around $j^*$, which depends on the degree of indistinguishability [11]. For fixed $M$, the normalized Young diagrams of the relevant sectors concentrate around the spectrum of the effective matrix $\rho_{\bar{n},\Gamma}$, in connection with the Keyl–Werner theorem and its extension to conditioning on fixed initial occupations [15]. However, this concentration does not determine the transition probabilities within each sector. For $M \geq 3$, weight spaces may exhibit internal multiplicity $m_\Lambda(n) > 1$, and the physical preparation conditioned on a sector of nonzero probability is described by the density matrix $\sigma_{\Lambda,n}(\Gamma)$, whose populations and coherences enter the transition probabilities. Determining their dependence on internal-state overlaps and the role of the different multiplicity directions is a central problem of this research.

The third correspondence connects the classical map with the semiclassical behavior of irreducible representations of $U(M)$. In the fully symmetric case, our previous work [12] used expansions based on virtual single-photon states to study multiphoton amplitudes through properties of single-photon transition amplitudes. For other representations, we have constructed pure states in the three-mode case by acting with the group on highest-weight states $|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle$ and projecting onto weight spaces $\mathcal{H}_{\Lambda,n}$. The compatibility of the frame with the initial occupations is equivalent to stationarity, at zero relative phases, of the action associated with the norm of the projected state. These constructions allow us to define sectorial classical maps $C_{\Lambda,V,U}(\phi)$ and establish exponential suppression bounds for transitions of projected states, provided that their initial norms are positive and not exponentially small. Building on these results, semiclassical approximations for representation matrix elements beyond the fully symmetric case will be formulated by identifying the contributions of stationary points, their prefactors, and the relative phases that determine their interference.

Together, these three correspondences define the central problem of this doctoral proposal: to establish, in the many-photon limit $N \to \infty$ with a fixed number of modes $M$, quantitative relations among the scattering probabilities of partially indistinguishable photons, the classical measure induced on the probability simplex by the map from relative phases to intensities, and the contributions of the irreducible sectors of $U(M)$. Although a correspondence has been established between the rescaled slowly varying component of the probabilities and the classical density at regular points, alongside an exact sector decomposition and concentration bounds for the statistical weights of the sectors under specific assumptions, the asymptotic behavior of the conditional transition probabilities and how their contributions relate to the full multiphoton distribution remain to be determined. To this end, we will determine how internal-state overlaps, described by the Gram matrix $\Gamma$, affect the populations and coherences of the physical density matrices $\sigma_{\Lambda,n}(\Gamma)$ in weight spaces with internal multiplicity. Furthermore, we will investigate how constructions based on multicoherent states can describe directions within these weight spaces and how they are related to the classical map. The semiclassical contributions associated with different preimages of the map and their relative phases will be calculated, and uniform Airy-type approximations near fold caustics and WKB-type approximations for classically forbidden regions will be formulated in configurations where they are applicable. Finally, semiclassical approximations for matrix elements of irreducible representations beyond the fully symmetric case will be developed, utilizing virtual states and constructions based on projected states to determine the contributions of stationary points, their prefactors, and relative phases.

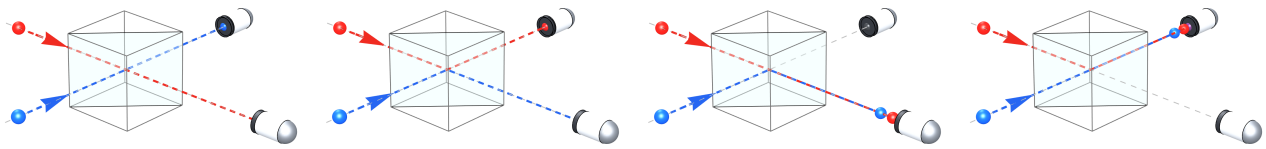
# 1 Physical motivation and the many-photon regime

In the physical setting considered here, $N$ photons enter a passive, lossless linear interferometer with $M$ optical modes and definite photon-number occupations at the input ports, corresponding to Fock-state preparations. The interferometer mixes the spatial modes, and the detectors measure the photon numbers at the output without resolving the internal states of the photons. Multiphoton interference arises because different propagation alternatives can lead to the same output occupation. When these alternatives are indistinguishable, their probability amplitudes add coherently, while partial distinguishability modifies the interference through the overlaps between the internal states of the photons.

In classical interferometry, by contrast, light is described by optical fields with amplitudes and relative phases, and interference is observed in the resulting output intensities. Optical coherent states provide a quantum description of such classical-like fields, but generally do not have definite photon numbers. When restricted to a fixed total photon number, these states can be expressed as symmetric tensor powers of single-photon states, although they do not generally have fixed occupations in each input mode. This contrast motivates the study of conditions under which the macroscopic behavior of multiphoton detection probabilities can be related to a classical description in the many-photon limit.

## 1.1 From two photons to interference in multiple modes

The Hong–Ou–Mandel effect shows how indistinguishability changes the detection probabilities of two photons [16]. Consider two perfectly indistinguishable photons entering different ports of a balanced beam splitter simultaneously. Fig. 2 shows the four alternatives involving transmission ($T$) and reflection ($R$), associated with their input ports.



(a) Both transmitted ($TT$); $(1,1)$. (b) Both reflected ($RR$); $(1,1)$. (c) Red $T$, blue $R$; $(0,2)$. (d) Red $R$, blue $T$; $(2,0)$.

Figure 2: Propagation alternatives for two indistinguishable photons in a balanced beam splitter. The letters $T$ and $R$ denote transmission and reflection, respectively. The alternatives $TT$ and $RR$ lead to the output occupation $(1,1)$, and their amplitudes interfere destructively, while $TR$ and $RT$ lead to the occupations $(0,2)$ and $(2,0)$. The colors indicate the paths associated with the input ports and do not represent distinguishable internal states.

To detect one photon at each output, both photons can be transmitted ($TT$) or reflected ($RR$). The coincidence amplitude is the coherent sum of these two contributions. For the single-photon transformation of a balanced beam splitter, we choose

$$U_{\mathrm{BS}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \mathcal{A}_{1,1} = U_{11}U_{22} + U_{12}U_{21} = 0. \tag{1.1}$$

The amplitudes $TT$ and $RR$ have equal magnitudes and opposite signs, so the coincidence amplitude vanishes through destructive interference. If the internal states are orthogonal, the probabilities of the two alternatives add, giving a coincidence probability of $1/2$. The bunching of indistinguishable photons results from interference, not from an attractive interaction.

Even with fixed $M$, increasing $N$ can increase the number of alternatives leading to the same output occupation. Their interference depends on the relative phases and on the input and output occupations. For perfectly indistinguishable photons, transition amplitudes are expressed in terms of permanents

of matrices constructed from $U$, with rows and columns repeated according to the occupations [17]. Their direct evaluation can become computationally costly as the number of photons $N$ increases.

Permanents also play a central role in boson sampling, where the number of modes may grow with $N$ [8]. In contrast, this proposal addresses the asymptotic limit $N \to \infty$ with a fixed number of modes $M$. Before formalizing this regime, the input preparation and detection model with partial distinguishability must be specified.

### 1.2 Preparation, partial distinguishability, and output probabilities

Consider a linear, passive, lossless interferometer with $M$ ports, described at the single-photon level by a unitary matrix $U \in U(M)$. At the input, $N$ photons are distributed according to the occupation $\boldsymbol{n} = (n_1, \ldots, n_M)$, with $\sum_i n_i = N$. The interferometer acts on the spatial modes, while the detectors record the output occupation $\boldsymbol{n}' = (n'_1, \ldots, n'_M)$, with $\sum_i n'_i = N$, without resolving internal degrees of freedom such as polarization, frequency, or temporal profile.

The analysis is restricted to the family of preparations considered in our previous work: the $n_i$ photons entering port $i$ share a pure, normalized internal state $|\chi_i\rangle$, while states associated with different ports may partially overlap. This assumption excludes arbitrary internal preparations, such as those with varying states for photons entering the same port or correlations not described by a common state for each port. Within this family, distinguishability between ports is characterized by the Gram matrix

$$\Gamma_{ij} = \langle \chi_j | \chi_i \rangle, \qquad \Gamma \succeq 0, \qquad \Gamma_{ii} = 1. \tag{1.2}$$

When all internal states coincide, $\Gamma_{ij} = 1$ and the photons are perfectly indistinguishable. At the opposite extreme, $\Gamma = I$ corresponds to orthogonal internal states for photons entering different ports, although photons entering the same port remain indistinguishable from one another. For partial overlaps, the complex entries of $\Gamma$ determine which contributions can interfere coherently and how they combine in the detection probabilities [6, 7].

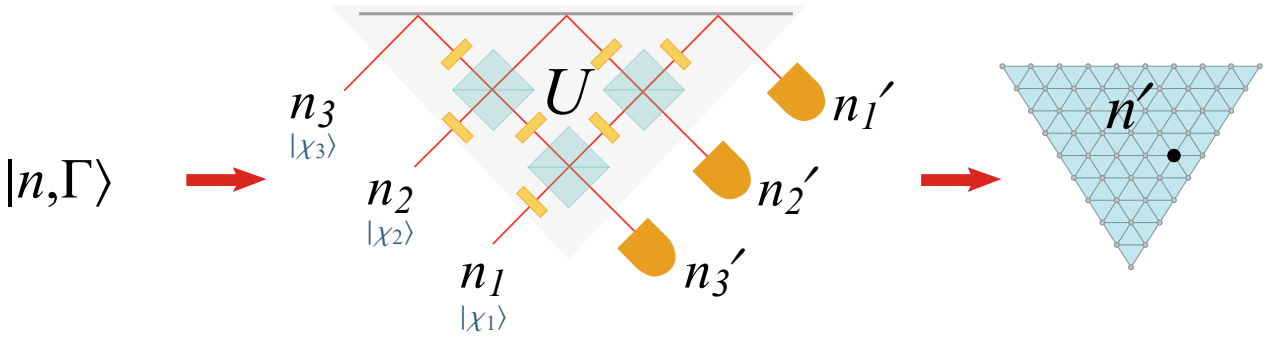



Figure 3: Schematic of the family of preparations considered in this work for a three-port interferometer. The $n_i$ photons entering port $i$ share an internal state $|\chi_i\rangle$, so partial distinguishability between ports is encoded in the overlaps $\Gamma_{ij} = \langle \chi_j | \chi_i \rangle$. The interferometer, described by the unitary matrix $U$, acts only on the spatial modes, while the detectors record the output occupations without resolving the internal states. Figure adapted from Fig. 1 of [12].

As illustrated in Fig. 3, for the same input occupation and interferometer $U$, changing the internal states $|\chi_i\rangle$ changes the overlaps in $\Gamma$ and may change the output probabilities. The probability of detecting the occupation $\boldsymbol{n}'$ is denoted by $P(\boldsymbol{n}' \mid U, \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma)$. Although exact expressions are available, the presence of spatial and internal degrees of freedom makes it difficult to identify interference patterns as the number of photons increases [6, 7]. The objective is to establish the asymptotic output distribution beyond individual probabilities. To achieve this, the input occupations and the Gram matrix $\Gamma$ will permit the formulation of an effective single-photon matrix which, together with the unitary $U$, defines the continuous classical map addressed in the next chapter.

### 1.3 The many-photon limit with a fixed number of modes

To quantify the macroscopic output distribution, the limit $N \to \infty$ is evaluated with $M$, $U$, and $\Gamma$ fixed, and sequences of input and output occupations whose fractions converge to $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$ and $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}'$, respectively:

$$N \longrightarrow \infty, \qquad M \text{ fixed}, \qquad \frac{\boldsymbol{n}}{N} \longrightarrow \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}, \qquad \frac{\boldsymbol{n}'}{N} \longrightarrow \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}'. \tag{1.3}$$

The normalized output occupations belong to the probability simplex $\Delta_{M-1} = \{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' : \overline{n}'_i \geq 0,\ \sum_i \overline{n}'_i = 1\}$. For $M = 3$, the simplex is a triangle whose points represent the fractions of photons detected at each port. This case allows us to study caustics, possible interior voids, and weight spaces with nontrivial internal multiplicity. For finite $N$, the possible occupations form a discrete lattice on the simplex that becomes finer as $N$ increases. This enables the determination of regions of asymptotic concentration or strong suppression on a macroscopic scale, while retaining the structure of interference oscillations on smaller scales.

Although the number of modes remains fixed, this does not eliminate quantum interference or make the calculation of individual probabilities trivial. For two ports, the asymptotic correspondence between multiphoton interference with partial distinguishability and a classical description was established in [11]. Our subsequent work extended this framework to multimode interferometers for a specific family of preparations, demonstrating that the classical measure induced by the map from relative phases to intensities governs the macroscopic behavior of the output probabilities [12].

The auxiliary relative phases parametrize this map, but the induced classical measure does not by itself determine quantum interference oscillations that may persist. The next chapter presents the construction of the map and the conditions under which the asymptotic correspondence holds.

## 2 Semiclassical structure of multiphoton interference

This chapter presents the correspondence between multiphoton probabilities and the classical measure induced by the map from relative phases to intensities, established for two ports and extended to multimode interferometers in our previous work [11, 12]. In the limit $N \to \infty$ with fixed $M$, we present the established results and their conditions of validity, as well as open problems concerning caustics and the determination of suppression rates in classically forbidden regions.

### 2.1 Effective single-photon matrix and relative phases

For the preparations of Sec. 1.2, the normalized occupations $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}} = \boldsymbol{n}/N$ and the Gram matrix $\Gamma$ define the effective single-photon matrix,

$$\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma} = [\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}]^{1/2}\, \Gamma\, [\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}]^{1/2}, \qquad [\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}] = \operatorname{diag}(\overline{n}_1, \ldots, \overline{n}_M). \tag{2.1}$$

Since $\Gamma \succeq 0$ and $\Gamma_{ii} = 1$, this matrix is positive semidefinite and satisfies

$$\operatorname{diag} \rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma} = \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}, \qquad \operatorname{Tr} \rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma} = 1. \tag{2.2}$$

The off-diagonal elements of $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$ contain the internal-state overlaps weighted by the occupations. In the classical description, $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$ is a normalized coherence matrix: its diagonal contains the relative input intensities, while its off-diagonal elements describe correlations between fields. It should not be confused with the reduced density matrix of the fixed-occupation multiphoton state.

In our previous work, we introduced auxiliary single-photon states, which we call *virtual states*, to express fixed-occupation multiphoton states exactly through a toroidal expansion in their tensor powers [12]. These auxiliary states are used in the mathematical expansion, rather than as alternative physical input preparations. At zero phases, the spatial marginal of a virtual single-photon state is $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$. The

expansion also gives an exact double-integral representation of the probabilities (Propositions 1 and 2 of the cited work). The phase matrix is defined as

$$t_{\boldsymbol{\phi}} = \mathrm{diag}\left(e^{\mathrm{i}\phi_1}, \ldots, e^{\mathrm{i}\phi_M}\right). \tag{2.3}$$

In the quantum expansion, the phases labeling the virtual states are auxiliary parameters and do not correspond to phases experimentally applied to the fixed-occupation state; in the classical description, they represent relative input phases. Removing the global phase leaves $M-1$ independent phases forming $\mathbb{T}^{M-1}$. Varying these phases with $U$ and $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$ fixed defines the classical map.

## 2.2 Classical map, allowed region, and induced measure

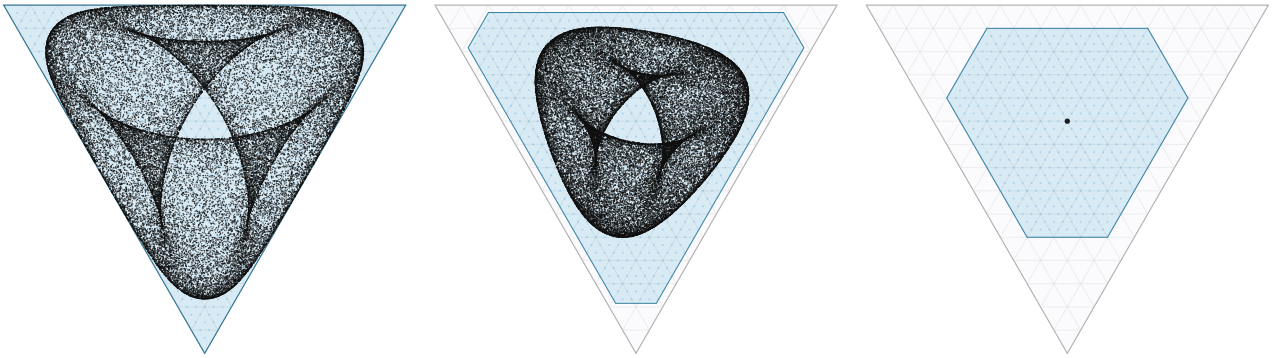
The propagation of the effective matrix through $U$, modulated by the phases $\boldsymbol{\phi}$, defines the classical map

$$C_{\rho,U}(\boldsymbol{\phi}) = \mathrm{diag}\left(U t_{\boldsymbol{\phi}} \rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma} t_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}^{\dagger} U^{\dagger}\right), \qquad C_{\rho,U} : \mathbb{T}^{M-1} \longrightarrow \Delta_{M-1}, \tag{2.4}$$

where $\Delta_{M-1}$ is the simplex of normalized intensities. The image of the map is the classically allowed region,

$$\mathcal{R}_{\rho,U} = C_{\rho,U}(\mathbb{T}^{M-1}) \subseteq \Delta_{M-1}. \tag{2.5}$$

For $M = 3$, Fig. 4 compares the images of the map on the triangular simplex for three degrees of indistinguishability, with the input occupation and interferometer fixed. Here $F_3$ denotes the three-mode discrete Fourier transform. By the Schur–Horn theorem, these images are contained in the corresponding spectral permutahedra, shown in blue, but need not coincide with them.



(a) Perfect indistinguishability. (b) Partial distinguishability. (c) Orthogonal internal states between ports.

Figure 4: Images of the classical map for $N = 45$ photons, with input occupation $\boldsymbol{n} = (30, 12, 3)$ and $U = F_3$, for three degrees of indistinguishability: (a) perfectly indistinguishable photons, $\Gamma_{ij} = 1$; (b) partial indistinguishability, $\Gamma = \Gamma_{\mathrm{par}}$, with $(\Gamma_{\mathrm{par}})_{12} = (\Gamma_{\mathrm{par}})_{13} = 1/\sqrt{2}$ and $(\Gamma_{\mathrm{par}})_{23} = (3 - \mathrm{i}\sqrt{3})/8$, together with unit diagonal entries and conjugate off-diagonal entries; and (c) orthogonal internal states between ports, $\Gamma = I_3$. The black points are images of relative phases sampled on the torus, while the blue regions represent the corresponding spectral permutahedra.

The induced classical measure is obtained by pushing forward the normalized uniform measure on the torus to the simplex through $C_{\rho,U}$. At regular points $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}'$, with discrete preimages and a nonzero reduced Jacobian, its density with respect to the independent simplex coordinates is

$$f_{\mathrm{clas}}(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \mid U, \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}, \Gamma) = \frac{\mathbf{1}_{\mathcal{R}_{\rho,U}}(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}')}{(2\pi)^{M-1}} \sum_{\boldsymbol{\phi}_\alpha : C_{\rho,U}(\boldsymbol{\phi}_\alpha) = \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}'} \left| \det\left( \frac{\partial C_{\rho,U}}{\partial \boldsymbol{\phi}} \right)_{\boldsymbol{\phi}_\alpha} \right|^{-1}. \tag{2.6}$$

The determinant is the reduced Jacobian in independent coordinates (for example, $\phi_1 = 0$ and

components $C_2, \ldots, C_M$); each preimage contributes the inverse of its absolute value. Caustics may arise where this Jacobian vanishes, at critical points where the regular formula fails and a different asymptotic treatment is needed. For $M \geq 3$, interior caustics and voids (interior regions without preimages) may occur. If $\Gamma = I_3$ and $U = F_3$, the image is the single point $(1/3, 1/3, 1/3)$, and the measure is concentrated at that point. The map delimits the forbidden region but does not, by itself, determine the quantum probabilities there or their behavior near caustics; the following theorems specify the scope of this correspondence [12].

### 2.3 Established asymptotic results

Three theorems of Ref. [12] make this correspondence precise.

*Concentration in the classical region.* Theorem 3 establishes the bound

$$P(\boldsymbol{n}' \mid U, \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma) \leq (N+1)^M \exp\left[-N D(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \| \mathcal{R}_{\rho,U})\right], \tag{2.7}$$

where $D(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \| \mathcal{R}_{\rho,U}) = \min_{\boldsymbol{\nu} \in \mathcal{R}_{\rho,U}} D(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \| \boldsymbol{\nu})$ and $D(\boldsymbol{x} \| \boldsymbol{y}) = \sum_i x_i \ln(x_i/y_i)$ is the relative entropy. At a positive distance from the allowed region, the bound implies exponential suppression as $N \to \infty$, but it determines neither the probabilities inside the region nor the exact suppression rates outside it. Its mathematical form is analogous to large-deviation bounds [18, 19].

*Limit of the macroscopic envelope.* $P_{\text{slow}}$ collects the diagonal contributions of the double integral. At regular points, Theorem 4 shows that its rescaled density, $f_{\text{slow}} = N^{M-1} P_{\text{slow}}$, converges to the classical density:

$$\lim_{N \to \infty} f_{\text{slow}}(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \mid U, \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}, \Gamma) = f_{\text{clas}}(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \mid U, \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}, \Gamma). \tag{2.8}$$

This limit does not, by itself, imply that quantum oscillations disappear.

*Suppression of rapid interference oscillations.* For generic interferometers and full-rank $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$, Theorem 5 establishes the asymptotic suppression of the off-diagonal interference contributions, so that

$$\lim_{N \to \infty} N^{M-1} P(\boldsymbol{n}' \mid U, \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma) = f_{\text{clas}}(\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}' \mid U, \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}, \Gamma), \tag{2.9}$$

both at regular points of the allowed region and in the forbidden region. This limit now concerns the rescaled physical probabilities.

If the initial occupation fractions are strictly positive, $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$ and $\Gamma$ have the same rank. Rank deficiency of $\Gamma$ is necessary, but not sufficient, for rapid interference oscillations to persist asymptotically; perfect indistinguishability ($\operatorname{rank}\Gamma = 1$) provides an example. These theorems do not provide uniform approximations near caustics or a general characterization of persistent interference.

### 2.4 Comparison with quantum probabilities and scope of the correspondence

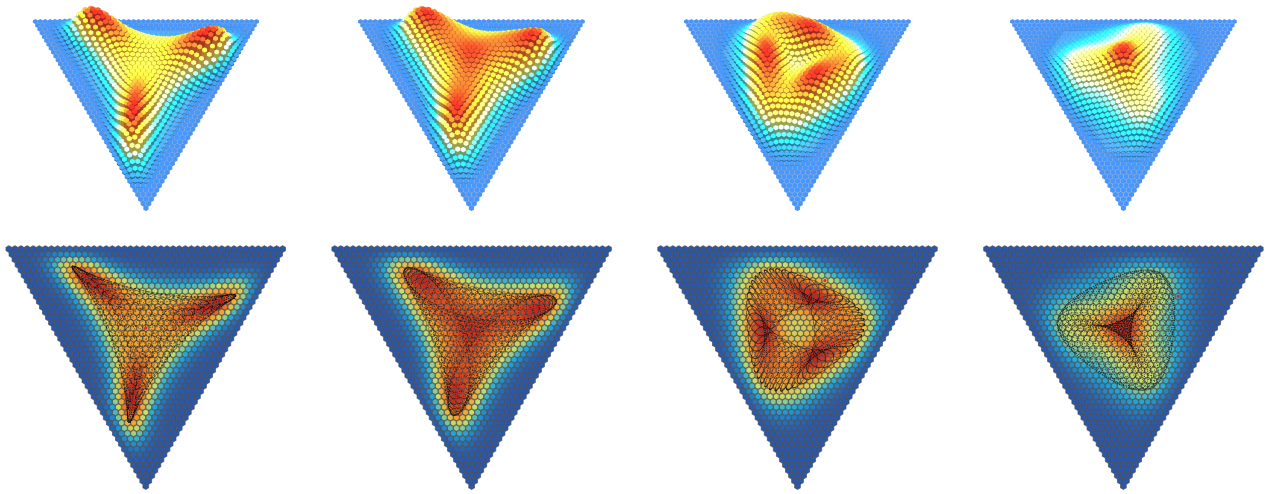
To compare multiphoton probabilities with the images of the classical map, four preparations are considered with $N = 45$, $U = F_3$, and a common effective spectrum $\boldsymbol{\lambda} = (11, 3, 1)/15$ (Table 1).

Table 1: Input occupations of the four preparations considered in Fig. 5, for $N = 45$ photons. The occupations $\boldsymbol{n}$ and their normalized forms $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}} = \boldsymbol{n}/N$ are shown.

| **Panel** | $\boldsymbol{n}$ | $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$ |
|---|---|---|
| (a) | $(15, 15, 15)$ | $(1, 1, 1)/3$ |
| (b) | $(15, 10, 20)$ | $(3, 2, 4)/9$ |
| (c) | $(24, 15, 6)$ | $(8, 5, 2)/15$ |
| (d) | $(27, 9, 9)$ | $(3, 1, 1)/5$ |

By the Schur–Horn theorem, $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}^{(j)} \prec \boldsymbol{\lambda}$ guarantees the existence of effective matrices with that spectrum

and diagonal, without uniquely determining their internal-state overlaps. Fig. 5 compares the output probabilities with sampled images of the map on the simplex.



(a) Balanced $\boldsymbol{n} = (15, 15, 15)$. (b) Asymmetric $\boldsymbol{n} = (15, 10, 20)$. (c) Intermediate $\boldsymbol{n} = (24, 15, 6)$. (d) More pronounced $\boldsymbol{n} = (27, 9, 9)$.

Figure 5: Comparison between multiphoton detection probabilities and the classical map for four preparations of $N = 45$ photons, with $U = F_3$ and a common effective spectrum $\boldsymbol{\lambda} = (11, 3, 1)/15$. The upper panels show the output probabilities using heights and colors, while the lower panels show the same probabilities on the simplex of normalized occupations, together with the black points obtained by sampling the classical map. The input occupations are indicated below each column.

For $\boldsymbol{\lambda} = \operatorname{spec} \rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$, the Schur–Horn theorem implies

$$\mathcal{R}_{\rho,U} \subseteq \Pi(\boldsymbol{\lambda}), \qquad \Pi(\boldsymbol{\lambda}) = \operatorname{conv}\{\pi\boldsymbol{\lambda} : \pi \in S_M\}. \tag{2.10}$$

The spectral permutahedron $\Pi(\boldsymbol{\lambda})$ does not necessarily coincide with the image of the map [12, 20]. With the same spectrum and interferometer, the four preparations give different images and quantum distributions whose macroscopic patterns reflect these differences. Thus, the spectrum alone determines neither the image of the map nor the output probabilities.

The comparison for $N = 45$ illustrates, but does not prove, the asymptotic limits of Sec. 2.3. At regular points, the induced classical measure describes the macroscopic envelope, but does not determine the individual contributions of the irreducible sectors of $U(M)$ or semiclassical approximations for matrix elements beyond the fully symmetric representation. These connections provide the basis for the following chapters.

# 3 Multiphoton interference and representation theory

Chapter 2 related multiphoton probabilities to the measure induced by the classical map [12]. Starting from this macroscopic description, we present the exact decomposition into irreducible sectors of $U(M)$, whose internal structure allows us to determine conditional probabilities that the classical map itself does not specify.

## 3.1 Input configuration, interference, and irreducible sectors

Figure 6 illustrates the three correspondences underlying this research through a common three-mode configuration. We consider $N = 45$ photons, initial occupation $\boldsymbol{n} = (15, 10, 20)$, and interferometer $U = F_3$. We choose the representation $\Lambda = (33, 9, 3)$ and a unitary matrix $V_1 \in U(3)$ satisfying

$\mathrm{diag}(V_1[\overline{\Lambda}]V_1^\dagger) = \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$, where $\overline{\Lambda} = \Lambda/N$. This choice determines an effective single-photon matrix with the prescribed spectrum and diagonal, and an associated Gram matrix $\Gamma(V_1)$. We refer to unitary matrices satisfying this condition as *compatible frames*; their construction is developed in the following chapter. The three panels show the total physical multiphoton detection probabilities, the image of the corresponding classical map, and the three-dimensional distribution of transition intensities obtained from the projected pure state associated with $V_1$ in the selected irreducible representation $\Lambda$.

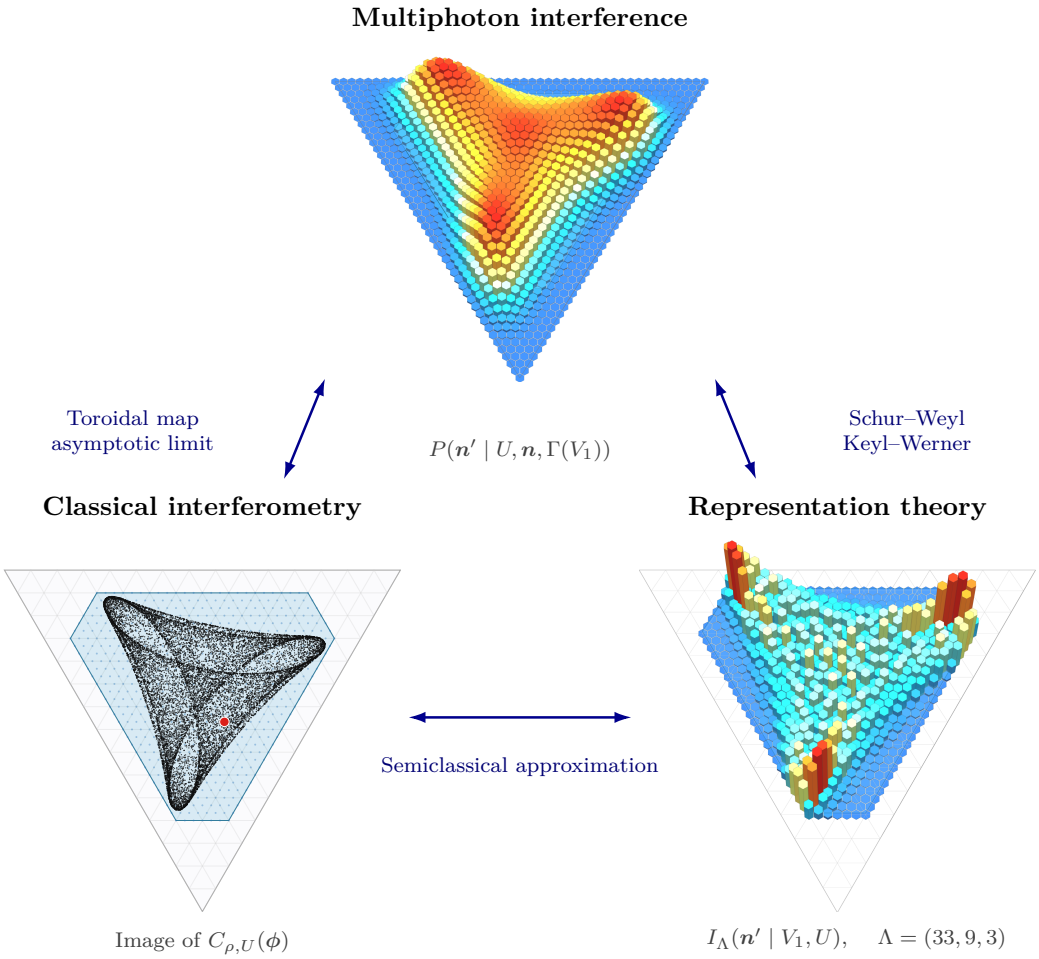



Figure 6: Correspondences between multiphoton interference, classical interferometry, and representation theory for $M = 3$, $N = 45$, $\boldsymbol{n} = (15, 10, 20)$, $U = F_3$, and the selected compatible frame $V_1$. Top: physical multiphoton detection probabilities, including contributions from all irreducible sectors. Left: sampled image of the classical map (black), spectral permutahedron (blue), and normalized input occupation $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}} = (1/3, 2/9, 4/9)$ (red). Right: three-dimensional representation of the output probabilities for the projected pure state associated with $V_1$ in $\Lambda = (33, 9, 3)$, obtained by summing the squared moduli of the outgoing isospin amplitudes. The upper connections indicate the quantum–classical asymptotic correspondence and the Schur–Weyl decomposition with Keyl–Werner concentration. The lower connection indicates the proposed semiclassical approximation of representation matrix elements beyond the fully symmetric case.

The first correspondence relates physical multiphoton probabilities to the classical map. As established in Chapter 2, the exact toroidal expansion yields a classical measure induced by the map from relative phases to normalized output intensities [12]. The black points in the lower-left panel sample its image, which is contained in the spectral permutahedron but need not coincide with it. In the many-photon limit, the rescaled slowly varying component of the probabilities converges to the induced classical density at regular points. Under additional conditions on the interferometer and the rank of the effective matrix, this also holds for the rescaled physical probabilities. The figure illustrates this correspondence at finite $N$, without establishing the asymptotic limit.

The second correspondence relates multiphoton interference to representation theory through the exact Schur–Weyl decomposition of physical probabilities into irreducible sectors. In the many-photon limit, the normalized Young diagrams concentrate around the effective single-photon spectrum under

the corresponding assumptions [15]. For the selected configuration, $\overline{\Lambda} = (11, 3, 1)/15$ coincides with this spectrum. The lower-right panel shows the output transition probabilities of a projected pure state associated with $V_1$ in $\Lambda = (33, 9, 3)$, obtained by summing the squared moduli of the outgoing isospin amplitudes at each output weight. The initial occupation $\boldsymbol{n} = (15, 10, 20)$ belongs to a weight space of multiplicity $m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n}) = 7$, distinct from the Schur–Weyl multiplicity. These probabilities do not generally coincide with the conditional physical sector probabilities, which depend on the populations and coherences of $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$.

The third correspondence connects the classical map with the semiclassical behavior of representation matrix elements. The two lower panels illustrate these descriptions for the same frame and representation. Beyond the fully symmetric case, determining the stationary-point contributions, their prefactors, and the relative phases governing their interference remains an open problem. The following chapter develops projected-state constructions and classical maps associated with irreducible representations to investigate this relation, without identifying projected-state transition probabilities with conditional physical sector probabilities.

### 3.2 Irreducible sectors, spectrum, and weight diagrams

With partial distinguishability, the reduced spatial description includes sectors that are not fully symmetric, although the full state retains its bosonic symmetry. Schur–Weyl duality organizes them as

$$(\mathbb{C}^M)^{\otimes N} \simeq \bigoplus_{\substack{\Lambda \vdash N \\ \ell(\Lambda) \le M}} \mathcal{H}_\Lambda \otimes \mathcal{M}_\Lambda. \tag{3.1}$$

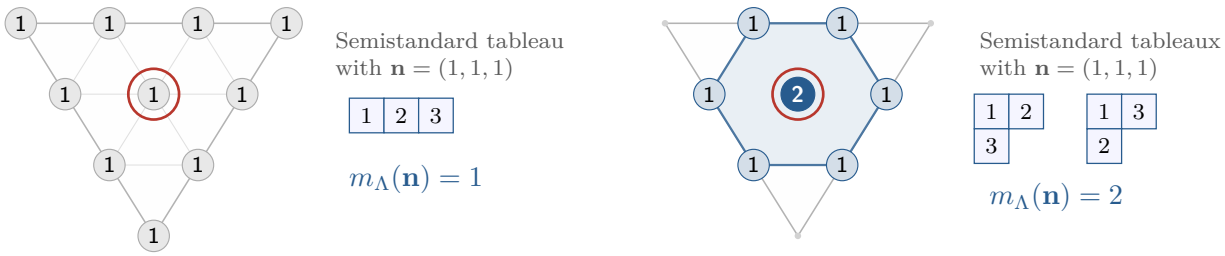
Each partition $\Lambda = (\Lambda_1, \ldots, \Lambda_M)$ of $N$ labels an irreducible representation of $U(M)$ acting on $\mathcal{H}_\Lambda$, with multiplicity space $\mathcal{M}_\Lambda$ [13, 14]. For $M = 3$, its $SU(3)$ Dynkin labels are $(p, q) = (\Lambda_1 - \Lambda_2, \Lambda_2 - \Lambda_3)$. The sector weights are related to $\boldsymbol{\lambda} = \operatorname{spec} \rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$. For product states $\rho^{\otimes N}$, Keyl and Werner proved the concentration of $\overline{\Lambda} = \Lambda/N$ around $\operatorname{spec} \rho$ [21]. When $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}^{\otimes N}$ is conditioned on the fixed occupation $\boldsymbol{n}$, whose probability is at least $(N+1)^{-M}$, the exponential bounds remain valid up to a polynomial factor (Appendix A). This concentration concerns the normalized irreducible labels, but does not determine the distribution within the weight spaces or the transition probabilities conditioned on each sector.

Each representation decomposes into weight spaces associated with the occupations:

$$\mathcal{H}_\Lambda = \bigoplus_{\boldsymbol{n}} \mathcal{H}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}, \qquad m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n}) = \dim \mathcal{H}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}. \tag{3.2}$$

The weight multiplicity $m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n})$ counts the internal directions associated with an occupation, distinct from the Schur–Weyl multiplicity $\dim \mathcal{M}_\Lambda$. The detectors do not resolve these directions, although the evolution may couple them.

The number of semistandard Young tableaux of shape $\Lambda$ and content $\boldsymbol{n}$ is $m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n})$. For $M = N = 3$, Fig. 7 shows ten weights of multiplicity one for $\Lambda = (3, 0, 0)$ and seven for $\Lambda = (2, 1, 0)$, with multiplicity two at $\boldsymbol{n} = (1, 1, 1)$. The convex hull of the normalized weights is the permutahedron $\Pi(\overline{\Lambda})$, which generally differs from $\Pi(\boldsymbol{\lambda})$ and the classical image $\mathcal{R}_{\rho,U}$. These internal multiplicities occur for $U(3)$, but not in irreducible representations of $U(2)$.




(a) Symmetric: $\Lambda = (3,0,0)$. (b) Adjoint: $\Lambda = (2,1,0)$.

Figure 7: Weight diagrams and semistandard Young tableaux of two representations of $U(3)$ for $N = 3$: (a) fully symmetric representation, $\Lambda = (3,0,0)$; (b) representation $\Lambda = (2,1,0)$, corresponding to the adjoint of $SU(3)$. The numbers indicate the weight multiplicities. The marked weight, $\mathbf{n} = (1,1,1)$, has multiplicity one in (a) and two in (b), as shown by the corresponding tableaux.

### 3.3 From the symmetric case to multiplicity spaces

For perfectly indistinguishable photons, each occupation corresponds to a unique Fock state in $\mathcal{H}_{(N,0,\dots,0)} = \mathrm{Sym}^N(\mathbb{C}^M)$; the amplitudes can be expressed in terms of permanents or representation matrix elements [17]. Semiclassical approximations are available for Wigner functions of $SU(2)$ and $SU(3)$ [22, 23]. In our previous work, known bosonic formulas were recovered using virtual single-photon states [12], motivating their extension to other representations.

With partial distinguishability, transition probabilities also depend on the preparation and the internal directions of each weight space.

The preparation is described by the normalized physical density matrix

$$\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma) = \frac{P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}} D^\Lambda(\Gamma) P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}}{\mathrm{Tr}\left[P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}} D^\Lambda(\Gamma) P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}\right]}. \tag{3.3}$$

Here $P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}$ projects onto $\mathcal{H}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}$, and $D^\Lambda(\Gamma)$ is the polynomial extension of the representation to $\Gamma$, which is not necessarily unitary. The density matrix is defined when $P(\Lambda \mid \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma) > 0$ and is positive semidefinite with unit trace (Appendix A). In a weight-space basis, its diagonal and off-diagonal entries represent populations and coherences, respectively.

If $\Gamma$ is positive definite, $\mathrm{rank}\,\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma) = m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n})$ (Appendix G); for $m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n}) > 1$, the physical density matrix is mixed and cannot be identified with a projected pure state. Parametrizing the internal directions using suitable preparations, compatible frames, and projected states is a central problem motivating the next chapter.

### 3.4 Physical probability as a sum of sector contributions

The exact decomposition of the physical probability is (Appendices A and G):

$$\begin{aligned} P(\boldsymbol{n}' \mid U, \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma) &= \sum_\Lambda P(\Lambda \mid \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma)\, P(\boldsymbol{n}' \mid \boldsymbol{n}, \Lambda, U, \Gamma), \\ P(\boldsymbol{n}' \mid \boldsymbol{n}, \Lambda, U, \Gamma) &= \mathrm{Tr}\Big[P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}'} D^\Lambda(U) \sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma) D^\Lambda(U)^\dagger\Big]. \end{aligned} \tag{3.4}$$

The first factor corresponds to the sector weight; the second, defined when $P(\Lambda \mid \boldsymbol{n}, \Gamma) > 0$, is the conditional probability. Only sectors with nonzero weight contribute to the sum; the trace accounts for internal directions not resolved by the detectors. The identity is exact for finite $N$.

The exact decomposition does not determine the asymptotic behavior of the conditional probabilities or how their contributions reconstruct the macroscopic distribution described by the classical map of Chapter 2. When all normalized initial occupations are positive, $\rho_{\overline{n},\Gamma}$ allows the reconstruction of $\Gamma$; however, characterizing transitions among the internal directions of weight spaces in the semiclassical

limit remains an open problem. The next chapter develops the compatible-frame condition, projected pure states, and classical maps associated with irreducible representations as analytical tools to study this problem, without identifying these pure states with the physical density matrix of a sector.

# 4 Progress toward semiclassical approximations for representation matrix elements

Chapter 3 identified transitions between weight spaces with internal multiplicity $m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n}) > 1$ as an open asymptotic problem. For three modes, we study these transitions using unitary matrices matching prescribed spectra and occupations, projected highest-weight states, and associated classical maps, distinguishing exact results, numerical evidence, and open questions.

## 4.1 Compatible frames and spectrum–diagonal geometry

Let $\Lambda = (\Lambda_1, \Lambda_2, \Lambda_3)$, $\sum_i \Lambda_i = N$, label an irreducible representation of $U(3)$, with $\overline{\Lambda} = \Lambda/N$. For $V \in U(3)$, consider the matrices

$$\rho_\Lambda(V) = V[\overline{\Lambda}]V^\dagger, \qquad Q(V)_{ij} = |V_{ij}|^2, \qquad \operatorname{diag}\rho_\Lambda(V) = Q(V)\overline{\Lambda}, \tag{4.1}$$

where $[\overline{\Lambda}]$ is diagonal and $Q(V)$ is unistochastic, and therefore bistochastic.

In this work, we call a unitary matrix $V$ a *compatible frame* for the normalized highest weight $\overline{\Lambda}$ and occupation $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$ if

$$Q(V)\overline{\Lambda} = \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}. \tag{4.2}$$

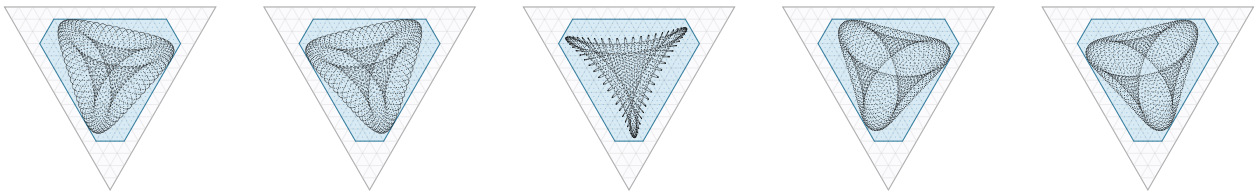
The Schur–Horn theorem guarantees the existence of compatible frames if and only if $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}} \prec \overline{\Lambda}$, without determining $V$ or the off-diagonal elements of $\rho_\Lambda(V)$ [20, 24]. For three modes, the bistochastic matrices $Q$ satisfying $Q\overline{\Lambda} = \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$ are characterized, and unistochasticity is imposed to reconstruct the frames [25]; Heron's criterion for triangle closure is detailed in Appendix B [26, 27].

The matrix $\rho_\Lambda(V)$ associated with $\Lambda$ and $V$ need not coincide with the physical effective matrix $\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$. If $\overline{n}_i > 0$ for all $i$, each compatible frame defines an admissible Gram matrix,

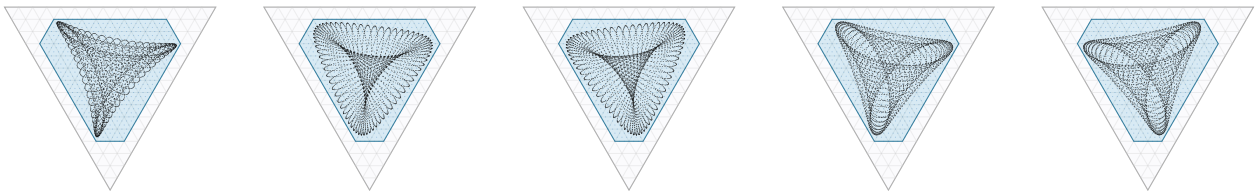
$$\Gamma(V) = [\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}]^{-1/2}\rho_\Lambda(V)[\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}]^{-1/2}. \tag{4.3}$$

Different compatible frames may produce different matrices $\Gamma(V)$, even with the same spectrum and initial occupation. Agreement with the physical matrix requires $\overline{\Lambda} = \operatorname{spec}\rho_{\overline{\boldsymbol{n}},\Gamma}$ and that $V$ diagonalizes it. In that case, the classical maps coincide, but transition probabilities obtained from projected pure states need not agree with those determined by the physical density matrix within the sector.

Fig. 8 compares ten compatible frames with fixed $\Lambda$, $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$, and $U$. Although they share the same spectrum and diagonal, the images of their associated classical maps differ because they depend on $V$ and the corresponding matrix $\Gamma(V)$. The points represent normalized classical intensities, not detection probabilities; the examples do not constitute an exhaustive classification.



(a) Frame $V_1$. (b) Frame $V_2$. (c) Frame $V_4$. (d) Frame $V_5$. (e) Frame $V_6$.



(f) Frame $V_7$. (g) Frame $V_9$. (h) Frame $V_{10}$. (i) Frame $V_{11}$. (j) Frame $V_{12}$.

Figure 8: Images of the classical map for ten compatible frames, with $N = 45$, $\Lambda = (33, 9, 3)$, $\overline{\boldsymbol{n}} = (1/3, 2/9, 4/9)$, and $U = F_3$. In each panel, the black points represent samples obtained by applying the map to relative phases on the torus, while the blue region corresponds to the common spectral permutahedron $\Pi(\overline{\Lambda})$. Although the spectrum, initial occupation, and interferometer remain fixed, the geometry of the image depends on the frame $V$.

### 4.2 Projected states and multiplicity directions in $SU(3)$

For perfectly indistinguishable photons, the relevant representation is fully symmetric, $\Lambda = (N, 0, 0)$. A normalized highest-weight vector is $|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle = |e_1\rangle^{\otimes N}$, whose orbit consists of the coherent states $D^\Lambda(V)|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle = |Ve_1\rangle^{\otimes N}$. Projection onto fixed-occupation weight spaces selects their Fock components and admits an exact Fourier representation over relative phases. This construction provides a link between representation matrix elements and the virtual-state method of Chapter 2, based on tensor powers of auxiliary single-photon states [12].

For general $\Lambda$, a normalized highest-weight vector $|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle \in \mathcal{H}_\Lambda$ is constructed in Appendix C from tensor products of exterior vectors $|e_1 \wedge \cdots \wedge e_r\rangle$ with multiplicities $p_r = \Lambda_r - \Lambda_{r+1}$ ($\Lambda_4 = 0$). Acting with $D^\Lambda(V)$ generates its unitary orbit $D^\Lambda(V)|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle$, a family of generalized coherent states [28] that we call *multicoherent states* in this work. Projecting an orbit state onto the weight space $\mathcal{H}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}$ and normalizing gives the pure state

$$|\boldsymbol{n}, V; \Lambda\rangle = \frac{P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}} D^\Lambda(V)|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle}{\sqrt{\mathcal{N}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(V)}}, \qquad \mathcal{N}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(V) = \left\| P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}} D^\Lambda(V)|\Omega_\Lambda\rangle \right\|^2, \tag{4.4}$$

provided that $\mathcal{N}_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(V) > 0$. The projector onto a weight space has an exact Fourier representation over the torus of relative phases (Appendix C). In the fully symmetric representation, each weight space is one-dimensional. For more general representations, weight spaces may have dimension greater than one, and different choices of $V$ can give distinct projected states at the same weight. A general semiclassical approximation for these transitions remains an open problem. For $SU(3)$, we use Gelfand–Tsetlin and isospin bases (Appendices C–F) [29, 30, 31].

In the adjoint representation of $SU(3)$, with $\Lambda = (2, 1, 0)$ and $\boldsymbol{n} = (1, 1, 1)$, two frames with the same $Q(V)$ are constructed whose projected states are orthogonal (Appendix F). This exact result demonstrates the importance of the phases of $V$, without implying differences between their isospin populations.

The linear independence of projected states is examined through their Gram matrices. For $N = 45$, $\Lambda = (33, 9, 3)$, families of states are found numerically to span the seven-dimensional weight spaces corresponding to $\boldsymbol{n} = (15, 15, 15)$, $(27, 9, 9)$, and $(15, 10, 20)$ (Appendix F). The rank criterion is exact, but the observed spanning is based on numerical evidence and does not guarantee that every direction

can be obtained from a single frame.

These pure projected states are not, in general, equivalent to the physical density matrix $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$ within the corresponding sector. Their transition probabilities are given by

$$P_{\mathrm{marco}}(\boldsymbol{n}') = \left\| P_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}'} D^{\Lambda}(U) |\boldsymbol{n}, V; \Lambda\rangle \right\|^2. \tag{4.5}$$

The conditional physical probabilities follow Eq. (3.4); for $N = 45$, the two descriptions are compared numerically and the isospin distributions are analyzed. By varying the compatible frame, the projected states can probe different directions of a weight space, as illustrated by the exact and numerical examples above. Whether this construction provides a general parametrization of those directions, and how it relates to physical density matrices, remain open questions.

### 4.3 Classical map associated with a representation and asymptotic results

In the toroidal representation, the compatibility condition $Q(V)\overline{\Lambda} = \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$ is equivalent to the stationarity of the action for the projected norm at the origin of the relative phases. If the reduced Hessian is positive definite and the required regularity conditions hold, a local Gaussian approximation is obtained. Extending it to the full integral requires controlling the remaining contributions (Appendix H). The macroscopic analysis of the projected-state transitions leads to a classical map defined by the representation label $\Lambda$ and the frame $V$ (Appendix I):

$$C_{\Lambda,V,U}(\boldsymbol{\phi}) = Q(U t_{\boldsymbol{\phi}} V)\overline{\Lambda} = \mathrm{diag}\left[U t_{\boldsymbol{\phi}} \rho_{\Lambda}(V) t_{\boldsymbol{\phi}}^{\dagger} U^{\dagger}\right], \qquad \mathcal{R}_{\Lambda,V,U} = C_{\Lambda,V,U}(\mathbb{T}^{M-1}). \tag{4.6}$$

By the Schur–Horn theorem, $\mathcal{R}_{\Lambda,V,U} \subseteq \Pi(\overline{\Lambda})$, although the image does not necessarily coincide with the permutahedron. This map identifies the region where the exponential penalty for transitions from projected pure states may vanish, but does not by itself determine their probabilities.

For normalized final occupations at a uniformly positive distance from $\mathcal{R}_{\Lambda,V,U}$, Appendix I establishes an exponential suppression bound, provided that the initial projected norms are positive and not exponentially small. Unlike the Gaussian approximations, this bound does not require regularity of the map. Determining prefactors, interference between stationary points, general semiclassical approximations for representation matrix elements, and their relation to the conditional probabilities of the physical density matrix $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$ remain open problems.

**Supplementary material and reproducibility.** The mathematical appendices supporting this proposal, together with the Wolfram Language code associated with the numerical calculations presented in this work, are available in the following GitHub repository: `https://github.com/orlandomelovargas/Multiphoton-Interference-Candidacy`.

## 5 Research problem and objectives

The preceding chapters presented the semiclassical correspondence between multiphoton probabilities and the measure induced by the classical map, the exact decomposition of these probabilities into irreducible sectors, and the constructions based on projected states and sectorial maps. These results provide a starting point for investigating how sector contributions relate to the multiphoton distribution and how classical maps can guide the development of semiclassical approximations for representation matrix elements.

### 5.1 Statement of the scientific problem

In the many-photon limit, we showed that probabilities are exponentially suppressed at a positive distance from the image of the classical map from relative phases to intensities, and that their rescaled slowly varying component converges to the density of the induced classical measure at regular points [12]. Under additional conditions on the interferometer and the rank of the effective matrix, this

convergence also holds for the rescaled physical probabilities. Open problems include determining the exact asymptotic rate functions, describing the behavior near caustics and across the transition between classically allowed and forbidden regions, and characterizing the interference that may persist when the effective matrix is not of full rank.

Schur–Weyl duality provides an exact decomposition of the physical probabilities into irreducible sectors (Eq. (3.4)). The normalized Young diagrams labeling these sectors concentrate around the spectrum of the effective matrix, in connection with the Keyl–Werner theorem and the result for fixed initial occupations proved in Appendix A [21]. This concentration does not determine the probabilities conditioned on each sector or their contributions to the total distribution. It remains to characterize how internal-state overlaps affect the populations and coherences of the physical density matrices in weight spaces with multiplicity, and to explore their internal directions and role in transitions.

Virtual single-photon states enable the semiclassical study of amplitudes in the fully symmetric representation [12]. For other representations, we have constructed projected pure states and sectorial classical maps (Eq. (4.6)), obtaining exponential suppression bounds for their transitions when the initial norms are positive and not exponentially small. The stationary contributions, their prefactors and interference remain to be determined, as does the relation between these constructions and the physical sector probabilities, without identifying projected pure states with physical density matrices.

The central problem is thus to relate, in the many-photon limit, the induced classical measure, multiphoton probabilities with partial indistinguishability, and the contributions of the irreducible sectors of $U(M)$, establishing the conditions under which semiclassical approximations can be obtained.

## 5.2 General objective

To establish quantitative correspondences among the scattering probabilities of partially indistinguishable photons in the many-photon limit $N \to \infty$ with a fixed number of modes $M$, the semiclassical behavior of irreducible representations of $U(M)$ in the limit of large Young diagrams, and classical multiport interferometry with partially coherent light, described by the classical map and its induced measure on the probability simplex.

## 5.3 Specific objectives

The specific objectives are organized around the three correspondences underlying this research.

### 1. Classical interferometry and multiphoton interference

To determine how the preimages and singularities of the classical map affect the asymptotic behavior of multiphoton probabilities, beginning with three-mode interferometers.

- **1.1.** To identify and classify the singularities of the classical map in selected configurations through its preimages and Jacobian, and quantify their effects on the probabilities.
- **1.2.** To determine bounds and decay rates for the probabilities in classically forbidden regions, establishing their relation to bounds based on relative entropy.
- **1.3.** To formulate and test uniform Airy-type approximations near fold caustics and WKB connection formulas between allowed and forbidden regions, under appropriate conditions.

### 2. Multiphoton interference and representation theory

To quantify how partial indistinguishability determines the contributions of the irreducible sectors of $U(M)$ and their weight spaces in the limit of large Young diagrams, beginning with $U(3)$.

- **2.1.** To characterize the distributions of statistical sector weights and quantify their concentration using Keyl–Werner bounds conditioned on fixed initial occupations.
- **2.2.** To determine how the populations and coherences of the physical density matrices $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$ enter the conditional probabilities and how these contribute to the full multiphoton distribution.

**2.3.** To parametrize the internal directions of weight spaces using compatible frames and projections of highest-weight orbit states (referred to as *multicoherent states* in Sec. 4.2), and to establish how these constructions relate to the physical density matrices within each sector.

**3. Classical interferometry and representation theory**

To construct semiclassical approximations for matrix elements of irreducible representations of $U(M)$ beyond the fully symmetric sector, using virtual states, projections onto weight spaces, and classical maps associated with irreducible representations.

**3.1.** To formulate suitable integral representations for matrix elements of irreducible representations beyond the fully symmetric case, identifying their stationarity conditions and their relation to the classical maps associated with these representations.

**3.2.** To determine, for selected families of $U(3)$ representations, the contributions of stationary points, their prefactors and relative phases, and compare the asymptotic formulas with exact and numerical results.

## 5.4 Scope and expected contributions

The research will initially focus on three-mode interferometers and representations of $U(3)$, where weight spaces with internal multiplicity $m_\Lambda(\boldsymbol{n}) > 1$ occur and the classical map may have interior caustics. Using Gelfand–Tsetlin bases, the isospin structures of $SU(3)$, and the exact and numerical results already obtained, quantitative correspondences will be investigated in specific configurations, within the general framework of the limit $N \to \infty$ with fixed $M$.

For the first correspondence, the singularities of the classical map and their effects on multiphoton probabilities will be characterized, determining bounds and rates of exponential suppression, and formulating Airy- and WKB-type approximations in configurations where they apply. For the second, the contributions of irreducible sectors to the multiphoton distribution will be quantified, considering the concentration of their statistical weights, the populations and coherences of the physical density matrices $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$, and the use of multicoherent constructions to describe internal multiplicity directions.

Finally, for the third correspondence, semiclassical approximations for matrix elements of irreducible representations beyond the fully symmetric case will be constructed, identifying stationary contributions, prefactors, and relative phases through virtual and projected states. The analytical results will be compared with exact and numerical calculations, distinguishing physical sector probabilities from transitions of projected pure states. A general treatment of more highly degenerate singularities, complex stationary points, and the systematic extension to an arbitrary number of modes will remain possible directions for future work.

## 5.5 Methodology

The methodology will combine representation theory, semiclassical methods, and symbolic and numerical calculations, building on the exact results already developed. The research will initially focus on three-mode interferometers, considering sequences of occupations $\boldsymbol{n}$ and representations $\Lambda$ such that $\boldsymbol{n}/N \to \overline{\boldsymbol{n}}$ and $\Lambda/N \to \overline{\Lambda}$ as $N \to \infty$, with fixed $M$.

For the first correspondence, the classical map $C_{\rho,U}$ will be analyzed through its preimages and Jacobians, identifying singularities, caustics, and voids. The induced classical measure will be compared with multiphoton probabilities for increasing values of $N$, examining contributions from different preimages and their relative phases where appropriate. Building on relative-entropy bounds, the rates of exponential suppression will be investigated and Airy- and WKB-type approximations will be formulated in configurations where the singularities and transitions between allowed and forbidden regions justify their use.

For the second correspondence, the exact decomposition of Eq. (3.4) and the concentration bounds associated with the Keyl–Werner theorem will be used. The statistical sector weights will be calculated

and the conditional physical probabilities will be analyzed using $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$ and its evolution under $D^{\Lambda}(U)$, examining how their populations and coherences contribute to the total distribution. For $SU(3)$, the isospin distributions and their moments will be determined, distinguishing the physical populations from the coefficients $c_j(V)$ of projected pure states. Through inner products and Gram matrices of these states, the generation of internal multiplicity directions and their possible description through multicoherent constructions will be evaluated.

Finally, for the third correspondence, we will implement constructions based on exterior powers, highest-weight orbits, and toroidal projections (Appendices C, H, and I), using the methods based on virtual single-photon states as a reference. Using stationarity conditions, reduced Hessians, and classical maps associated with irreducible representations, we will develop semiclassical approximations for matrix elements of representations beyond the fully symmetric case in selected configurations. We will examine the contributions of stationary points, their prefactors and relative phases, together with the conditions of validity and exponential suppression bounds. The results will be compared with exact and numerical calculations, distinguishing transitions of projected pure states from physical sector probabilities.

## 5.6 Ethical considerations

The research is theoretical and computational and therefore does not involve experiments with humans or animals or the processing of personal data. The main ethical considerations concern academic integrity and the reproducibility of the results. Proper attribution of previous work and documentation of the analytical and numerical procedures used will be strictly ensured. Furthermore, proved results, numerical evidence, and hypotheses yet to be verified will be explicitly distinguished, stating the conditions of validity and limitations of the approximations developed.

## 5.7 Timeline

The work plan covers doctoral semesters 7–10 and is organized around the three correspondences underlying the specific objectives. Building on the results already obtained, the analysis of the classical map, the characterization of sector contributions, and the development of semiclassical approximations for representation matrix elements will be carried out.

Table 2: Tentative timeline.

| **Period** | **Planned activities and results** |
|---|---|
| Semester 7 | Characterization of singularities, caustics, and voids of the classical map in three modes using preimages and Jacobians. Calculation of bounds and rates of exponential suppression, and evaluation of Airy/WKB approximations in appropriate configurations, with comparisons against exact probabilities. |
| Semester 8 | Calculation of statistical sector weights and their concentration. Analysis of conditional physical probabilities, populations, and coherences of $\sigma_{\Lambda,\boldsymbol{n}}(\Gamma)$, and exploration of multiplicity directions using compatible frames, projected states, and multicoherent constructions. |
| Semester 9 | Development of semiclassical approximations for matrix elements of $U(3)$ using virtual states and toroidal projections. Determination of stationary contributions, prefactors, and relative phases. Quantification of their relation to sector probabilities and the induced classical measure, with exact and numerical comparisons. |
| Semester 10 | Integration and validation of results, determination of the conditions of validity of the approximations, and identification of open problems. Preparation of manuscripts, final thesis writing, and defense. |

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